Cues and Details (v0.0.1)[1]

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This chapter contains a collection of cues that I have found useful for teaching Italian rapier. Most of these should be self-explanatory, but I have tried to include some of my thoughts, as well as some of the over-corrections I have observed, for each. It also contains a number details that either didn't fit anywhere else, or are generally applicable.

1. Cues

1.1. General

Explosive Impetus

Cue: Most actions (lunge, incartata, etc.) consists of two parts: an explosive impetus, and an attempt to not face-plant as a result of that. Focus on the explosive part, and let the rest take care of itself.

Notes: Sometimes students are too focused on finishing an action in a particular position, or on looking a particular way when they move. Both of these are useful things to work on from time to time, but they can also lead to slow, tense, awkward movement. Focussing instead on the explosive impetus, and letting the body worry about keeping your nose from making contact with the floor, can be a good way to alleviate that. In my experience, moving well is a case where form follows function.

Pitfalls and Over-corrections: Not everyone has good control of their body. That is not an eternal judgement, but a weakness one can—and should!—work on. For those who are not there yet, however, this cue is unlikely to work right away. But it can be a good starting point for working on body control. A few pitfalls I have observed:

- Putting way too much energy into the explosive part and ending up in an awkward position.
- Focussing so hard on being explosive that one forgets what the movement is supposed to accomplish.

'Long Guard'

Cue: Create a straight line from your elbow, through the cross of the hilt, to the point of the rapier.

Notes: When holding the rapier in what some call a 'long guard', that is, the rapier is held parallel to the ground, some have a tendency to stick out their elbow, or otherwise uncovering their weapon arm. This cue often helps with that.

[1] This document is part of a collection of texts on Italian rapier fencing, and may reference parts that are not included here. The current version of the full collection can be found on https://github.com/laugedideriksen/ItalianRapier.

Pitfalls and Over-corrections: Fencers who are not yet comfortable gripping the rapier (see below), often start doing weird things with their wrist to create the line.

1.2. Specific Movements and Actions

Incartata/Scanzo: end position

Cue: Head over shoulders over arse.

Notes: When first learning rotating voids, especially incartata and scanzo, many tend to finish the movement leaning backwards or with their head at a weird angle. Focus on finishing with the head and upper body stacked on top of each other—that way it is easier to change direction.

1.3. Developing the Guard

Finding the Guard in the full collection

2. Details

Gripping the Rapier

Different treatises give different (often vague) instructions for holding the rapier. Saviolo gives what is perhaps the most important piece of advice: "For your Rapier, holde it as you shall thinke most fit and commodious for you" (Saviolo 1595, 7). Here are a few details that have helped me to that end:

- don't squeeze the handle. As a matter of fact, hold it as loosely as possible and only give it a squeeze at the moment of impact in e.g. a parry.
- find a way to let the weapon 'hang', for me that is between the hook of my index finger and the pinky-side of the base of my palm (the *hypothenar eminence*).
- don't push the index finger all the way through. Depending on the geometry of the hilt, my index finger wraps around the quillon at the distal joint or phalange (the joint or segment furthest away from the hand).
- I sometimes rest the pommel against my wrist
- in the same way as there is no one best guard, there is no one grip that is best for every situation, find a way to hold the rapier that allows you to move it in your hand.

2.1. Footwork

Front Foot

The line of the front foot should bisect the opponent's centre of balance.[2]

[2] I first heard this one from George Livermore of the *1595 Club*'s Milano chapter.

Knees over Toes

There is nothing inherently dangerous about the knee moving out in front of the toes e.g. in a lunge. There is, however, something inherently dangerous in forcing both knee and ankle into an unfamiliar range of motion by throwing the majority of your bodyweight onto it with great motivation. There are good reasons to train this range of motion, only some of which have to do with fencing. When fencing, however, there are also good reasons to not always to into the deepest lunge of which one is capable, mainly that it can be slow and awkward to get out of. As is so often the case, there are costs and benefits.

References

Saviolo, Vincentio. 1595. *His Practise. In Two Bookes. The First Intreating of the Use of the Rapier and Dagger. The Second, Of Honor and Honorable Quarrels*. London.